

DEFENCE | INDIA-US DRONE DEAL

A LONG DRONE PROCESS

India is all set to buy the MQ-9B drones that will give it unmatched strike and surveillance capability. But with the deal only at the start of a long acquisition process, it may take long before the military can lay its hands on an MQ-9B

By Pradip R. Sagar

IN recognition of the increasing importance of Unmanned Aerial Vehicles (UAVs) or drones over the modern battlefield, and after years of deliberations and analysis, the Indian armed forces have decided to acquire 31 MQ-9B High Altitude Long Endurance (HALE) UAVs manufactured by General Atomics of the US. This was announced in the India-US joint statement during Prime Minister Narendra Modi's state visit to the US in June. The MQ-9B has two variants—the SkyGuardian and the SeaGuardian, its maritime variant. India will acquire 15 SeaGuardians for the Navy and 16 SkyGuardians—eight apiece for the Indian army and air force. Ten drones are expected to be procured as readymade units, while the remaining 21 will be assembled in India. The deal—estimated at $3.07 billion (over Rs 25,000 crore) by the US—will be